



# CAUSAL MAPPING APPROACHES DIFFER IN APPLICATION, CONSTRUCTION, ANALYSIS AND HOW THEY DEAL WITH MULTIPLE SOURCES

| Reference                                                                       | Main application of causal mapping                                                                                                 | Mode of construction                                                                                                                        | Dealing with multiple sources                                                   | Analysis procedures                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| (Axelrod, 1976)                                                                 | Understand and critique decision making                                                                                            | Coding documents                                                                                                                            | Mainly idiographic                                                              | Compute polarity of indirect effects in some cases.                                                                                                                                                                        |
| (Bougon et al., 1977)                                                           | Understand how organisations are constructed and can be influenced.                                                                | Semi-structured interview to identify a fixed list of factors aka 'variables'; respondents then say which are linked and give the polarity. | Compare individual maps and combine into global 'average' map.                  | Identify variables X with high outdegree and Y with high indegree and construct an 'etiograph' to show all the multiple paths from one point to another; discuss how respondents might have influence over some variables. |
| (Ackermann and Eden, 2004, 2011; Eden, 1992; Eden et al., 1979, 1992)           | Decision support and problem solving in organisations. Maps are seen primarily as useful tools rather than research about reality. | Open interviewing of several respondents based on Kelly's Personal Construct Theory. Also map construction directly with groups (1988).     | Comparing maps between individuals and analysing group maps directly.           | Various structural measures, presence of isolated clusters, hierarchical trees, loops. Simplify individual maps by collapsing X->Y->Z into X->Z.                                                                           |
| (Laukkanen, 1994, 2012; Laukkanen and Eriksson, 2013; Laukkanen and Wang, 2016) | Explicitly cognitive, to improve knowledge and understanding in management                                                         | Systematic comparative method with semi-structured interviewing: respondents are given anchor topic(s) then asked for causes,               | Comparative study of different individual maps, combining data into a database. | Display combined maps for subgroups, e.g. all local managers.                                                                                                                                                              |

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|-----------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------|
|           |                                    | effects, causes of causes, effects of effects. Compress the data by standardising factor names. Comprehensive coverage of different map construction possibilities. |                               |                     |

## Related

- [chapter intro](#)